the same lineage as some other Parsi stalwarts such as Dadabhai Naoroji, Pherozshah Mehta and Bhikaji Cama.

When the communal violence of December 1992–January 1993 shook Bombay, it caused Ratan immense anguish and anxiety. It engendered in him a strong emotional response and his reaction was sharp and defiant, spawned as it were by his deep patriotic values. ‘A son of Bombay’s soil Ratan Tata wept as he saw his city torn asunder amid the shanties at Asia’s largest slum, Dharavi,’ wrote a leading newsmagazine.

Emotionally wounded, Ratan fought against divisive forces and to safeguard the nation’s larger interests, he dared to even risk the economic fortunes of the Tata Group. In what Reuters described as a ‘highly unusual move’—as ‘Indian businessmen rarely’ make ‘public statements on political and religious issues’—Ratan condemned the destruction of the Babri masjid, which had brought on the communal riots, and called it a ‘wanton act’ that would ‘remain as a dark moment in India’s history’. He remarked that ‘all right-thinking Indians must feel a great sense of shame’ for the crisis that swept the city.

In an audacious move, the soft-spoken Ratan openly criticized the political leadership for fuelling the flames of communal hatred. He said that while he worried about the ‘immediate fall-out’ of the demolition of the mosque on India’s economic environment and criticized it, he minced no words in blaming the political leadership and said: ‘I really feel this is a sad moment in our history and it is unforgivable that political parties have fanned religious sentiments.’

He gave vent to his consternation by going public with his views. Distraught by the deaths and destruction, Ratan published an appeal in a leading newspaper on 19 January 1993 declaring that it was from ‘an anguished heart’. The appeal, for which he paid personally, was signed ‘Ratan N. Tata, A Concerned Citizen’. It was a clarion call for ‘all citizens of Bombay to stand up and be counted, regardless of [their] religious faiths and regardless of whether [they were] rich or poor’. He went on to reprimand the people of the city who did not openly oppose the carnage. In the appeal he queried: ‘Through all this carnage where were the real people of Bombay? Where were the people who care—the people who love their city—the people who have lived together amicably? What were the real citizens of Bombay doing while Bombay was burning or while their